Lead Broker Blueprint by Lorenzo Marietti

Module 5 — The Lead Generation Side

Cold-to-Warm Lead Conversion Playbook

The exact scripts, objection responses, transfer language, routing logic, and an end-to-end HVAC funnel walkthrough — for the moment your business actually starts making money.

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How to use this playbook

This playbook lives alongside Module 5 (The Lead Generation Side) and the Intake Script Templates. The curriculum teaches you what the moving parts are. The script templates give you starter scripts for four verticals. This playbook covers everything in between those two — the execution detail that separates a $0 operator from a $50,000-a-month operator.

Read it once start to finish before you take your first call. Then come back to Parts 2 and 3 every time you train a new agent or onboard a new vertical. Part 6 is your end-to-end mental model — read it twice a year as a refresher.

What this playbook covers

- Part 1 — The first 30 seconds: how to sound legitimate, not like a telemarketer, and earn the right to ask qualification questions.
- Part 2 — The objection handling bank: exact responses to the nine objections that kill 70% of qualified leads, broken down by vertical.
- Part 3 — The warm transfer: word-for-word transition language for handing the consumer off to the buyer with maximum acceptance probability.
- Part 4 — Borderline lead recovery: techniques for converting almost-disqualified leads into qualified ones without compromising buyer trust.
- Part 5 — Multi-buyer routing: how to decide in real time which of your buyers gets which lead, across auction, round-robin, tier-based, and geo+tier models.
- Part 6 — End-to-end HVAC funnel walkthrough: every step from Google search to final invoice, with dollar amounts at each stage so the unit economics become concrete.

Three operating principles

Before you read another word, internalize these. Everything in this playbook descends from them.

1. The consumer is always the customer — even when the buyer is paying you.

Sellers who treat the consumer as inventory get caught quickly: dispute rates spike, buyer satisfaction craters, and you lose accounts. Sellers who treat the consumer as the customer (whose problem your buyer can solve) produce qualified leads buyers fight to pay more for. This isn't a moral position. It's a strategic one. Every script in this playbook is built around making the consumer feel respected.

2. Specificity is the difference between trust and suspicion.

Generic openings ("Hi, this is Mike from ABC Marketing") destroy trust. Specific openings ("Hi Sarah, this is Mike from RestoreLine — I'm calling about the air-conditioner-replacement quote request you

submitted at 11:23 this morning for the property on Maple Avenue") build it. The data is in the form; use it. People relax instantly when they realize you actually know who they are and why you're calling.

3. The transfer is the entire business.

Everything before the warm transfer is preparation. Everything after is reporting. The transfer itself — the 30 seconds where you hand the consumer to the buyer with the buyer already on the line — is where the money is made. Every script, objection response, and qualification question in this playbook is engineered to maximize the probability that the transfer succeeds and that the buyer accepts the lead.

Part 1 — The first 30 seconds

Consumer research is unambiguous on this: 60-70% of trust judgments in a cold call are formed in the first 30 seconds. After that window, you're either earning more trust or losing it — but the baseline is set. If you blow the opening, no amount of script skill recovers it.

This section gives you the architecture of an opening that consistently produces 50%+ qualification rates (vs. the 15-25% you'll get with a generic opening) on inbound callback flows.

The four-element opening

Every opening should contain exactly these four elements, in this order. Don't add to it. Don't reorder it. Don't extend it. The whole opening should take 12-15 seconds.

1. Their name first (~2 seconds)

Say the consumer's first name — and only the first name — before you say anything else. This is the single highest-leverage word in the entire call. Hearing your own name from a stranger triggers an instant attention response. Even a half-second pause after their name ("Sarah?") works.

> *"Hi Sarah —"*

2. Your full name + the firm name (~3 seconds)

Use your full first and last name. Use the actual buyer's firm name if you're calling on the buyer's behalf, or your own brand name if you're running the seller-side intake. NEVER use "ABC Marketing," "the team," or any other generic. Specific names sound real because they are.

> *"...this is Marcus Chen from RestoreLine HVAC."*

3. Why you're calling, with a timestamp (~5 seconds)

Reference the form they submitted, the page they visited, or the ad they clicked, WITH a specific timestamp. The timestamp is what proves you're real. Spam callers don't have timestamps. Legitimate callbacks do.

> *"I'm calling about the air-conditioner-replacement quote request you submitted at 11:23 this morning for the property on Maple Avenue."*

4. Permission to continue (~3 seconds)

Ask if it's a good time. This single sentence does three things: it shows respect, it surfaces objections immediately (so you handle them now rather than 90 seconds in), and it gets the consumer's first "yes" — which materially increases the probability of subsequent yeses.

> *"Do you have about five minutes to walk through the details so we can get a quote scheduled?"*

The complete opening, end to end

> *"Hi Sarah — this is Marcus Chen from RestoreLine HVAC. I'm calling about the air-conditioner-replacement quote request you submitted at 11:23 this morning for the property on Maple Avenue. Do you have about five minutes to walk through the details so we can get a quote scheduled?"*

13 seconds, total. Read it out loud once. Notice how natural it sounds compared to anything you've ever received from a telemarketer.

Tone and pacing

Pacing

Slow down. The single most common error new agents make is talking too fast in the first 15 seconds because they're nervous. Fast pacing reads as scripted, anxious, or robotic. Slow pacing — about 130-145 words per minute, with brief pauses between sentences — reads as confident and conversational.

Practical drill: read the four-element opening above out loud, deliberately taking 14-15 seconds. If you finish in under 12, you're rushing.

Tone

Aim for what voice coaches call "the curious neighbor" — warm, professionally interested, not over-energetic. Smiling slightly while you talk actually does change the sound of your voice; consumers can hear it. Don't fake-smile through the whole call, but smile through the opening.

What to avoid: the customer-service uplift (every sentence ending in a rising inflection), the call-center monotone (every sentence at identical pitch and volume), and the over-eager salesman (volume too high, energy too aggressive).

Mirroring

By 30-45 seconds in, gently match the consumer's pacing and energy. If they're terse and quick, become terse and quick. If they're chatty and casual, become chatty and casual. Mirroring is well-documented in social psychology research as a trust accelerant. Don't overdo it — match their style, don't imitate them.

Common opening mistakes that immediately blow trust

- Opening with your name before theirs. "Hi, this is Marcus from RestoreLine — am I speaking with Sarah?" sounds like every telemarketer the consumer has ever hung up on. Their name first.

- Generic firm names. "ABC Marketing," "Home Services Group," "the customer service team" all sound fake because they are. Use a specific firm name or your own.
- Vague references. "I'm calling about a request you submitted" — when? for what? Be specific or sound suspicious.
- No timestamp. "Earlier today" is not a timestamp. "At 11:23 this morning" is.
- Asking permission too late. If you launch into qualification questions before getting the consumer's first yes, you'll get cut off when they decide they don't want to talk.
- Mentioning the buyer too early. "I'm calling on behalf of three HVAC contractors in your area" sets off alarm bells. The buyer comes up later — at the warm transfer.
- Disclaimers and disclosures upfront. Recording disclosures, TCPA disclaimers, and similar legal language must be delivered, but not before you've earned the right to keep them on the call. Place these in the middle of the call, not the opening.

Vertical-specific opening considerations

Personal injury

The consumer is in pain or recovering. Slow your pace another 10-15%. Use the word "care" or "taking care of" early. Avoid the word "case" in the opening — it sounds clinical and reminds them this is legal. Switch to "case" in the qualification phase.

> *"Hi James — this is Anna Reyes from Burns & Mateo, the law firm in Pasadena. I'm calling about the accident-recovery inquiry you submitted at 2:48 yesterday afternoon. I just want to make sure we're taking care of you properly — do you have about ten minutes to walk through what happened?"*

Medicare

Older consumer. Increase volume slightly. Slow pace another 15%. Use "appointment" or "benefits review" — never "sales" or "selling." Some consumers will be hard of hearing; speak clearly, not slowly to the point of condescension.

> *"Hi Margaret — this is Daniel from SeniorCare Advisors. I'm calling about the Medicare-benefits review you requested at 10:15 this morning. Do you have about ten minutes to go over your current coverage with me?"*

Mortgage purchase

Time-sensitive. The consumer is often actively shopping. Move faster than other verticals (~150 wpm). Mention "rate" or "pre-approval" early — that's what they're calling for.

> *"Hi David — this is Kara Singh from Cornerstone Lending. I'm calling about the pre-approval inquiry you submitted at 9:07 this morning. I have a rate to walk through with you — do you have about seven minutes?"*

Part 2 — The objection handling bank

Nine objections account for 90%+ of the early-call drop-offs in inbound-callback lead generation. This section gives you exact responses for each one, broken out by vertical.

Two operating principles for objection handling:

1. Don't argue. Every response below acknowledges the objection before redirecting. Never use the word "but" — use "and" instead. "That makes sense, and here's what I want to clarify..." lands; "That makes sense, but..." puts the consumer on the defensive.
2. Don't lie. If you can't truthfully answer an objection (e.g., "How did you get my number?" — you bought it), pivot to a true and relevant statement (you got it from a marketing partner the consumer engaged with). Lying produces dispute rates that destroy your account.

Objection 1 — "Is this a sales call?"

The most common objection. Honest answer required (FTC Telemarketing Sales Rule). Acknowledge it, frame the call accurately, restore the consumer's autonomy.

Universal frame

> *"Fair question. I'm not selling anything on this call. I'm following up on the [specific thing they submitted] you asked about at [timestamp]. My job is to confirm the details and connect you with [the appropriate service provider] if it looks like a fit. If it's not a fit, we'll wrap up and you won't hear from me again."*

HVAC

> *"Fair question. I'm not selling anything on this call. I'm following up on the quote request you submitted at [time] for the [property type] on [street]. My job is just to confirm the details and get a contractor scheduled for the on-site estimate. If you've already gotten quotes elsewhere or changed your mind, just say so and we'll wrap up."*

Medicare

> *"Fair question. I'm not selling you anything on this call — and I'm not allowed to. I'm following up on the benefits review you asked about at [time]. My job is to look at your current Medicare situation with you and see if there's a better-fitting plan available in your area. If your current plan is the best one for you, I'll tell you that."*

Mortgage

> *"Fair question. I'm not selling you a loan on this call. I'm following up on the pre-approval inquiry you submitted at [time]. My job is to confirm the basics — credit,*

> *income, the property you have in mind — and put a real rate quote in front of you. If our rate isn't competitive with what you're already seeing, you'll know in five minutes and we can wrap up."*

Personal injury

> *"I understand — and I want to be clear: I'm not a salesperson. I'm with [Firm Name], the law firm. I'm following up on the case-evaluation request you submitted at [time]. My job is to listen to what happened and see if it's the kind of case our attorneys handle. There's no cost to talk; there's never any cost unless we win."*

Objection 2 — "How did you get my number?"

This objection signals either suspicion or sincere curiosity. Either way, answer truthfully and specifically. Mentioning the form they filled out is usually enough.

Universal frame

> *"You filled out the [specific form name or landing page] at [timestamp] — that's the request I'm following up on. If you have a moment I can read back the details you submitted so you can confirm it was you."*

If they actually want you to read back the details, do it (name, zip, service requested). 95% of the time the moment you offer, the objection resolves and you proceed.

When the consumer doesn't remember submitting the form

Common with multi-person households and with consumers who fill out multiple comparison sites. Don't argue. Confirm details: "Are you the homeowner at [address]? Were you looking at [service] in the last day or two?" If it's still no, polite close: "Sounds like there may have been a mix-up — I'm sorry for the call. Have a good day." Then mark the lead as bad-data in your CRM.

Objection 3 — "I'm just looking for information."

Means the consumer is in research mode, not yet decision mode. Don't push to a transfer — instead, lower the perceived stakes and earn permission to do qualification.

Universal frame

> *"Totally fine — most people we talk to are still researching when they call us. The way it usually works is: I ask a few questions to understand what you're looking for, then I can give you real information based on your specific situation instead of generic answers off the internet. That takes about five minutes. Worth it?"*

Notice the structure: validate, normalize ("most people"), reframe ("real information" vs. internet generic), small commitment ("five minutes, worth it?"). The "worth it?" lands because it's a low-cost yes.

Objection 4 — "I want to think about it."

Usually surfaces at the qualification or transfer stage. Don't pressure. Pivot to scheduling a callback and capture commitment for the callback.

Universal frame

> *"Of course — this isn't something to rush. What I'd like to do is get [the buyer] to call you back at a time that works for you, instead of you waiting on us. Is tomorrow at [specific time options] better, or later in the week?"*

Always offer specific time options, never "when's good for you?" — the latter often produces "I don't know, I'll call you back" (which means never).

Objection 5 — "Can you send me something in writing first?"

This is a polite brush-off in most verticals. Don't refuse — instead, capture the email and use the request as a wedge to do qualification.

Universal frame

> *"Happy to. So I can send you the most relevant information instead of generic marketing material, can I ask three quick questions first? Then I'll send you exactly what fits your situation."*

Then do basic qualification (3-4 questions). After that you're warmed up enough to attempt the transfer or schedule callback. ALWAYS follow up with the email regardless of whether they convert — promises kept on cold calls become referral sources later.

Objection 6 — "Why do you need [piece of personal info]?"

Common around credit score, income, SSN, full date of birth. The consumer is right to ask. Answer honestly with the specific reason.

Mortgage — credit score range

> *"It's the single biggest factor in the rate I can quote you, so without an approximate range I can't give you a real number. I'm not asking for the exact score, just a range — under 620, 620-680, 680-740, 740 plus. That's enough for me to put a real rate in front of you."*

PI — at-fault question

> *"It changes which states you have a viable case in. Some states bar recovery if you're more than 50% at fault, others reduce by percentage. I want to make sure our attorneys can actually help you before we take more of your time."*

Medicare — prescription medications

> *"Medicare Part D plans cover different medications at different costs. The right plan for you depends on what you take. I'm not asking for medical history — just the drug names, so I can find the plans that include them."*

Objection 7 — "Is this going to cost me anything?"

Honest, direct answer. Then redirect.

Free-consult verticals (PI, Medicare, HVAC estimate, mortgage pre-approval)

> *"No. This call is free. The [consultation / estimate / pre-approval] is free. There's no obligation at any point. The way this works is [vertical-specific brief]: you only pay if you decide to move forward and you're happy with what's being offered."*

Objection 8 — "I'm not interested anymore."

Acknowledge, ask one question to understand, accept the answer if they hold. Never argue out of a "not interested."

Universal frame

> *"Got it — happens. Mind if I ask: did you already get this taken care of somewhere else, or was it just bad timing? Just so we don't keep bothering you if it's resolved."*

If "already taken care of": disqualify cleanly, wish them well. If "bad timing": gently re-engage — "When would be better timing to circle back? I'll put it on our calendar so you don't have to remember us." If they still hold the "not interested," close politely and revoke consent in the CRM.

Objection 9 — "I already talked to someone."

Very common in high-volume verticals (HVAC, mortgage). The consumer submitted forms on multiple sites and several callers reached them. Don't compete by talking down the other party.

Universal frame

> *"Makes sense — a lot of folks compare a few options. Out of curiosity, have you already scheduled [the estimate / consult / appointment]? Because if you haven't, I can usually*

> *get you in sooner than most, and a second [estimate/quote/opinion] is the standard way to confirm you're getting a fair number."*

Key move: normalize comparison-shopping ("a lot of folks"), then offer the second-opinion / speed-to-schedule advantage. Avoid bashing the competition.

Part 3 — The warm transfer

The warm transfer is the highest-leverage 60 seconds in your entire business. Done well, it produces buyer-accepted leads at 75-90% rates — sometimes higher in tight-vertical operations. Done poorly, it produces 30-40% accept rates, dispute spirals, and account churn.

Four components, in order: the pre-transfer setup, the whisper to the buyer, the three-way introduction, and the disengage.

Component 1 — The pre-transfer setup (the last 30 seconds before transfer)

Before you initiate the transfer, the consumer should know exactly what's about to happen. Surprise transfers fail. Telegraphed transfers succeed.

Universal language

> *"OK — based on what you've told me, you're a great fit for [the buyer description: e.g., one of our HVAC partners / our staff attorney / one of our licensed Medicare advisors]. What I'd like to do right now is connect you with [Specific Buyer Name] so you can talk directly. They're going to ask you a couple of the same questions I just asked — sorry about that — and then they'll walk you through [next step]. The call will take about [time estimate]. Hold for just a moment while I get them on the line."*

Key elements: name the specific buyer, set the time expectation, warn about repeated questions, signal the disengage.

Component 2 — The whisper to the buyer

While the consumer is on hold, you brief the buyer in 10-15 seconds. The whisper is delivered via the call platform's whisper feature (Ringba, CallRail, Phonexa, Boberdoo all support this). The buyer should hear the whisper before they hear the consumer.

HVAC whisper template

> *"Hot lead — [First Name], [City], [property type], current system [age] years, [issue brief], qualified, ready for an estimate, not yet talking to other contractors. Connecting you now."*

PI whisper template

> *"PI lead — [First Name], [State], [accident type], [time since accident], injuries [severity], currently in treatment, not represented, [at-fault status]. Connecting you now."*

Medicare whisper template

> *"Medicare lead — [First Name], [State], age [X], currently on [plan type], [election period], primary concern is [drug coverage / network / cost]. Connecting you now."*

Mortgage whisper template

> *"Mortgage lead — [First Name], [State], purchase, [credit range], [household income range], [timeline], property [identified or in search]. Connecting you now."*

Critical: whisper details must match what the consumer told you. If the buyer asks about credit score and the consumer's answer doesn't match the whisper, your credibility with the buyer collapses and dispute risk skyrockets.

Component 3 — The three-way introduction

The moment all three of you are on the line. Your job is to introduce, validate the consumer's time, hand off authority cleanly. 15-20 seconds total.

Universal three-way intro

> *"Sarah, I have [Buyer Name] on the line — they handle [vertical-specific role: HVAC estimates in your area / Medicare planning / pre-approvals / case intakes] and I think they'll be able to help you. [Buyer Name], Sarah is the [property/situation summary] I just walked you through."*

Then — and this is the move 90% of new agents get wrong — you go silent. Don't keep talking. Don't ask if they need anything else. Don't say "I'll let you two take it from here." Just stop. The silence is the handoff.

Component 4 — The disengage

30-45 seconds after the three-way intro, once the buyer has started their conversation, drop off the line silently. If your platform requires a verbal disengage, use a single short phrase.

Verbal disengage (if required)

> *"I'll let you two take it from here. Sarah, great talking with you."*

Don't add "thank you for your time," "best of luck," or anything else. Each extra phrase reminds the consumer that this is a transactional setup.

Vertical-specific transfer compliance considerations

Personal injury — recording disclosure

Most states require notice that the call is being recorded. Many sellers deliver this notice at the start of the call. If the buyer's intake also records, the buyer typically delivers their own disclosure when they take over.

Medicare — CMS rules

Medicare Advantage and Part D telemarketing is heavily regulated. Recording disclosure required. SOA (Scope of Appointment) must be completed before any plan discussion — usually the licensed advisor handles this after the transfer. Confirm the buyer is licensed in the consumer's state BEFORE transferring.

Mortgage — RESPA, ECOA

Don't mention specific rates the buyer hasn't pre-cleared. Don't promise approval. RESPA prohibits steering and certain referral kickbacks; confirm your buyer relationship structure is compliant.

HVAC — least regulated

Few special compliance considerations. State-licensed contractor required in some states; confirm the buyer holds the required license in the consumer's state if applicable.

What to do when the transfer fails

Buyer doesn't answer. Buyer's queue is full. Buyer drops the call mid-conversation. All of these happen. Have a recovery script ready.

If the buyer doesn't answer the whisper

> *"Sarah, give me one moment — let me pull in a second specialist instead so we can take care of you today."*

Then attempt your second-choice buyer in the routing rotation. If no buyer is available, schedule a callback rather than letting the consumer hang up disappointed.

If the transfer drops mid-call

Your platform should automatically reconnect with you in the loop. Once reconnected: "

> *"Sarah — sorry about that, dropped call. Let me try [Buyer Name] again, hold one second."*

Part 4 — Borderline lead recovery

About 25-40% of inbound calls fall into a borderline zone — not clearly qualified, not clearly disqualified. Most agents disqualify these out of habit. Trained agents recover 30-50% of them into qualified status. That recovery rate alone, applied to the full call volume, can change a money-losing operation into a profitable one.

Five techniques. Each works on different types of borderline leads.

Technique 1 — The "yes ladder"

Small confirmations build to a commitment. Used when the consumer is interested but cautious. Each "yes" raises the probability of the next yes.

HVAC example

Setup: consumer says they're "probably 6-9 months out" from replacing.

> *"OK — so the system is still working, just on its last legs?" → yes.*
>
> *"And you'd rather replace before it fully fails so you're not stuck without AC in summer?" → yes.*
>
> *"Would it make sense to have a contractor come out for a free estimate now, so you have a real number to work with when you're ready to decide?" → typically yes.*

Result: a borderline 9-month lead becomes a qualified estimate appointment within 2 weeks.

Technique 2 — Reframe the timeline

When the consumer cites a future timeline, identify what they actually need NOW to be ready then.

Mortgage example

Setup: consumer says "we're not buying for 4-6 months."

> *"Got it — so you're in the planning phase. The biggest mistake people make is starting to look at houses without knowing exactly what they can afford. A pre-approval today doesn't commit you to anything, and it locks in your rate eligibility for [X days]. That's usually the first step pros recommend. Worth doing now while we have you on the phone?"*

Result: the consumer wasn't ready to buy today — but they're ready for a pre-approval today, which IS the lead the buyer is paying for.

Technique 3 — Comparative-jurisdiction monetization

PI specifically. Some states (modified comparative negligence — at-fault below 50% can still recover) extend the qualified pool well beyond "clearly not at fault." Know your buyer's jurisdiction rules.

Example

Setup: consumer says "I think I was partially at fault."

> *"OK — partial fault doesn't necessarily disqualify you, depending on your state. [State] is a [pure / modified / contributory] negligence state, which means [explanation]. The attorney I'd connect you with handles these cases all the time. Worth letting them assess?"*

Caveat: only use this if your buyer actually handles modified-comparative cases. Confirm with the buyer's intake spec sheet before deploying.

Technique 4 — The structured callback

When the consumer is genuinely not ready, schedule the callback with maximum probability of conversion. Two rules.

3. Specific time. "Wednesday at 3:15 PM" not "sometime next week." Calendar-block precision dramatically increases callback show rates.
4. Calendar invite. Send a calendar invite to the consumer's email within 60 seconds of the call ending. Industry data: calendar-invite-confirmed callbacks show up at 75-85%; verbal-only callbacks show up at 30-40%.

Universal language

> *"OK, totally understand. I'm going to put us down for Wednesday at 3:15 PM — does that work? Great. I'll send you a calendar invite with [Buyer Name]'s direct number so you have it. If something comes up, just reply to the invite to reschedule. Sound good?"*

Technique 5 — The ethical cross-vertical pivot

Rarely used, but real. When a consumer is clearly disqualified for one vertical but you operate in another that fits them, mention the alternative — IF and ONLY IF your relationship with them remains consent-respecting. Never make assumptions about what they want.

Example

Setup: PI caller, but they're calling about an old accident outside the statute of limitations.

> *"Unfortunately the statute of limitations in [state] has run on this — there's nothing our attorneys can do. I want to ask though: when something like this happens, sometimes people are also dealing with [medical debt / disability claims / etc.]. If any of that applies and you'd find it useful, I can connect you with someone who handles those cases — totally separate from this call, totally up to you."*

Important: never present a cross-vertical pivot as a save. Present it as an offer the consumer can decline. Track these separately in your CRM — they're often a meaningful secondary revenue stream once you have the right relationships in place.

Part 5 — Multi-buyer routing logic

Once you have more than one buyer for a vertical, you have to make a real-time decision about which buyer gets which lead. The decision affects revenue per lead, buyer satisfaction, dispute rates, and capacity utilization across your roster.

Five common routing models. Most mature operations use a combination of them.

Model 1 — Auction (ping/post)

The lead's basic data (zip, demographic markers, qualification flags) is sent to multiple buyers simultaneously as a "ping." Each buyer responds with a bid. The highest bidder gets the "post" — the full lead data with PII.

When to use it

- High-volume verticals with many active buyers (mortgage, insurance, education).
- Mature operations with established buyer relationships and an LMS (lead management system) that supports ping/post — Boberdoo, LeadConduit, Leadspedia, Phonexa all do.
- Verticals where lead value varies significantly by buyer (some buyers will pay much more for a lead matching their ideal customer profile).

When NOT to use it

- New operations with only 1-3 buyers — overhead exceeds benefit.
- Pay-per-call verticals where the lead is a live caller — ping/post is designed for form leads.
- Highly-regulated verticals (PI in some states, Medicare) where buyer-by-buyer compliance is required.

Mechanics

5. Ping fires with: zip, age range, lead-grade signals (qualification flags), creative source.
6. Buyers respond within a time window (typically 100-500 ms) with bid amount or no-bid.
7. LMS awards the lead to the highest bidder.
8. Post fires with full PII to the winning buyer; the consumer is contacted on whatever schedule the buyer's intake operates.

Model 2 — Round-robin

Leads are distributed sequentially across your active buyer roster. Each buyer in rotation gets the next lead matching their spec sheet.

When to use it

- Small buyer roster (2-5 buyers) where you want to keep all buyers reasonably fed.
- Buyers with similar payouts per lead — no need to maximize per-lead via auction.
- Capacity-constrained buyers where overload is more painful than missing the highest possible price.

Mechanics

9. Maintain a rotation order in your LMS.
10. For each new lead matching spec, route to next buyer in rotation; advance the pointer.
11. Skip buyers who are at daily/hourly cap; skip buyers offline; resume rotation at next qualifying buyer.
12. Reset rotation pointer daily or weekly to avoid first-buyer-always-loses dynamics.

Model 3 — Tier-based (waterfall)

Buyers are ranked by payout (Tier 1 = highest, Tier 3 = lowest). Each lead is offered to Tier 1 first; if no Tier 1 buyer accepts (capped, offline, declined the specific lead), the lead falls to Tier 2; then Tier 3.

When to use it

- Wide payout variance across buyers — Tier 1 pays $300/lead, Tier 3 pays $80.
- Highly variable lead quality — better leads should flow to higher-paying buyers, lower-quality to bargain buyers.
- Pay-per-call funnels where you want premium buyers to get first crack at every live caller.

Mechanics

13. Define tiers in your LMS by payout band: Tier 1 ($X+), Tier 2 ($Y-X), Tier 3 (<$Y).
14. Within each tier, run either round-robin or auction.
15. Fall-through rules: if a Tier 1 buyer declines a specific lead, fall to Tier 2 within [time window]; same for Tier 2 to Tier 3.
16. After max fall-through, mark the lead as undeliverable; refund or expire per your buyer agreements.

Model 4 — Geo + tier (the most common production setup)

Buyers are segmented by geography (state, metro area, zip), then tiered within each geo. The lead's zip determines the candidate set; tiers determine the order within that set.

Why this is the production default

Service businesses (HVAC, attorneys, contractors, dentists, etc.) operate in specific geographies. A consumer in Tampa is worthless to a contractor in Phoenix. Pure auction would route the lead to whoever bids highest regardless of fit. Geo+tier routes only to buyers actually able to serve the consumer, and then maximizes price within that constrained set.

Mechanics

17. Each buyer's spec sheet defines: served zips (or states / metros), tier, daily/hourly caps, lead quality requirements.
18. Lead arrives → LMS filters candidate buyers by geo match.
19. Within the geo-filtered set, run tier waterfall: offer to Tier 1 first, fall through if declined or capped.
20. If no candidate accepts within the time window, mark undeliverable and either refund or sell to a backup network.

Model 5 — Exclusive single-buyer

Some sellers operate exclusive relationships — every lead in a vertical/geo goes to one buyer, period. Used when the buyer pays a premium for exclusivity and the seller's volume is small enough not to need diversification.

When to use it

- Buyer pays 2-3x the auction rate for exclusivity.
- Volume is too low to support multi-buyer overhead.
- Strategic relationship — the buyer is your highest-trust partner and the relationship justifies foregone bid optimization.

Risks

- If the buyer churns, the whole vertical's revenue stops overnight.
- No competitive pricing benchmark — you may be underpriced and not realize it.
- Buyer-side capacity constraints become your capacity constraints.

Caps and pacing

Regardless of routing model, every buyer should have caps. Caps prevent buyer overload (which kills lead quality) and protect your account relationships.

Cap types

- Daily cap — max leads per day. Most common. Resets at midnight in the buyer's local time zone.

- Hourly cap — max leads per hour. Use when the buyer's intake team is small.
- Concurrency cap — max in-flight calls at any moment. Use for live transfer.
- Weekly cap — max leads per calendar week. Use when daily fluctuation is acceptable but weekly drift isn't.

Pacing

Even within a daily cap, distribute leads evenly across business hours rather than dumping them all at 9 AM. Most LMSs support "smart pacing" — calculate cap ÷ business hours, route at that rate.

Reporting back to the buyer and the seller dashboard

Every lead that flows through your routing should generate two reports: one for the buyer (so they can validate the lead's match to spec), one for you (so you can invoice and track performance).

Buyer-facing report (delivered with each lead or on a rolling dashboard)

- Timestamp, source, consumer name, contact info.
- Qualification answers — every question asked and the consumer's answer.
- TrustedForm certificate URL — proof of the consumer's consent to be contacted.
- Recording (for phone-based intake), if your platform captures.
- Disposition: transferred / scheduled callback / form lead delivered.

Seller-side dashboard

- Lead volume by source, vertical, geo.
- Qualified-rate, transfer-accept rate, dispute rate per buyer.
- Revenue per lead, per buyer, per source.
- Buyer capacity utilization — who's at cap, who's underutilized.
- Returns and disputes — track to identify quality drift or buyer cherry-picking.

Part 6 — End-to-end HVAC funnel walkthrough

This section walks through one complete lead, from Google search to final invoice, with dollar amounts at each step. The example is fictional but the mechanics, costs, and conversion rates are based on operator-reported norms for HVAC replacement in mid-tier metros (Tampa, Phoenix, Las Vegas, Charlotte, Indianapolis) as of mid-2026.

Read this twice. Once for the mechanics. Once for the unit economics.

The setup

You operate as a lead-generation seller in the HVAC replacement vertical. You serve the Tampa metro. You have three buyers — local contractor networks — each with capacity for 8-15 leads per business day.

Your three buyers:

- ComfortPro HVAC — Tier 1, pays $230 per qualified estimate appointment. 4.9/5 customer rating. Caps at 12/day.
- Suncoast Air — Tier 2, pays $185 per qualified estimate appointment. Caps at 15/day.
- BreezeFix — Tier 3, pays $145 per qualified estimate appointment. Caps at 8/day.

Your routing: geo+tier, with all three buyers serving the same metro. Tier 1 gets first crack; falls to Tier 2 then Tier 3 if declined/capped.

Step 1 — The consumer search

Tuesday, 11:23 AM. Sarah Martinez, 47, homeowner in Brandon FL (Tampa metro), Googles "AC replacement quote Tampa". Her 18-year-old central AC has been struggling and her latest electric bill was 40% higher than the prior month.

Step 2 — The ad

Sarah sees three sponsored results at the top of the SERP. She clicks the first one: a Google Ads search ad from your operation.

Headline

> *"Tampa AC Replacement — Free Quote in 24 Hours | Top-Rated Local Contractors"*

Description

> *Compare quotes from licensed Tampa-area HVAC contractors. Free, no-obligation estimates. New systems from $4,800 installed. Same-week appointments available.*

Ad mechanics

- Keyword: "AC replacement Tampa" — broad match modified, max bid $11.
- Cost per click in this auction: $7.42.
- Ad uses dynamic keyword insertion for the headline ("AC Replacement" pulled from her query).

Your ad-spend cost for Sarah's click so far: $7.42.

Step 3 — The landing page

Sarah lands on your /tampa-ac-replacement page. Mobile-optimized, loads in 1.8 seconds.

Above the fold

- Headline: "Get 3 Tampa AC Replacement Quotes in 24 Hours."
- Sub-headline: "Top-rated local contractors. Free, no obligation. Average system $4,800-$8,200 installed."
- Hero image: a clean photo of a new AC unit on a Florida home.
- Single CTA: "Get My Free Quote" button.
- Trust signals: BBB Accredited Business badge (real), "Licensed Florida HVAC Contractors" badge.
- Phone number with click-to-call (mobile).

Below the fold

- 3-step explainer: "Tell us about your home → Match with 1-3 local contractors → Schedule your free in-home estimate."
- FAQ: "Is this really free? How fast can someone come out? Are you contractors or a marketplace?"
- Footer: privacy notice, terms, do-not-sell opt-out, business address, license disclosure.

Step 4 — The form

Sarah clicks "Get My Free Quote". A multi-step form appears.

Step 1 of 4 — ZIP and service

- ZIP code: 33511 (Brandon FL).
- Service: AC Replacement.

Step 2 of 4 — Property

- Property type: Single-family home.
- Are you the homeowner? Yes.
- Approximate square footage: 1,500-2,000.

Step 3 of 4 — Timeline and system

- Current system age: 16+ years.
- Timeline: "As soon as possible."
- Current issue: "System is still working but high bills."

Step 4 of 4 — Contact

- First name, last name.
- Phone (mobile).
- Email.
- Best time to contact: "Anytime today."
- PEWC consent checkbox with clear disclosure of which parties may contact her, by what means, and her right to revoke consent.
- TrustedForm certificate URL automatically captured on submission.

Form completion takes Sarah 1 minute 47 seconds. The completion rate for this 4-step funnel hovers around 38% (versus 18-22% for a single-page equivalent).

Step 5 — Lead arrives in your CRM

11:24 AM. Sarah's submission appears in your LeadConduit instance with the following data captured:

- All form fields above.
- UTM parameters showing the ad and keyword.
- TrustedForm certificate URL (consent proof).
- IP address, browser fingerprint.
- Lead score (LeadConduit's automatic scoring): 78/100 — "high quality."

Step 6 — Routing decision

LeadConduit evaluates the lead against your buyer spec sheets:

21. Geo match: Tampa metro. All three buyers serve it.
22. Tier 1 (ComfortPro): currently at 5/12 daily capacity. Offered the lead first.
23. ComfortPro's spec sheet auto-accepts: homeowner, system 10+ years, ASAP timeline. Match.
24. ComfortPro accepts the lead within 800 milliseconds.

Tier 2 and Tier 3 are not offered this lead. ComfortPro pays you $230.

Step 7 — Phone callback (the speed-to-lead moment)

11:26 AM — three minutes after Sarah's submission. Your call center (or your own outbound dialer) initiates the callback. Speed-to-lead is the single biggest determinant of qualification rate in HVAC — operator data consistently shows 80%+ contact rate within 5 minutes vs. 30-40% after an hour.

Your agent Marcus dials Sarah's mobile number. The number used is a Ringba-issued tracked number that displays your brand name and Tampa area code.

Sarah picks up on the second ring.

Step 8 — Intake script execution

Opening (12 seconds)

> *"Hi Sarah — this is Marcus Chen from RestoreLine HVAC. I'm calling about the air-conditioner-replacement quote request you submitted at 11:23 this morning for the property on Maple Avenue. Do you have about five minutes to walk through the details so we can get a quote scheduled?"*

Sarah: "Yes, that's great — I was actually hoping someone would call back quickly."

Qualification (3 minutes)

Marcus walks the standard HVAC qualification:

- Homeowner confirmed. ✓
- System age 18 years. ✓
- Timeline ASAP. ✓
- ZIP 33511 → confirmed in ComfortPro's service area. ✓
- Not currently in conversation with another contractor. ✓
- Approximate budget: "open, depends on what's needed." (No hard disqualification on budget for HVAC replacement.)

Pre-transfer setup (30 seconds)

> *"OK Sarah — based on what you've told me, you're a great fit for one of our top-rated Tampa-area contractors. What I'd like to do right now is connect you with Erik from ComfortPro HVAC so you can talk directly. He's going to ask you a couple of the same questions I just asked — sorry about that — and then he'll walk you through scheduling the on-site estimate. The call will take about ten minutes. Hold for just a moment while I get him on the line."*

Step 9 — The warm transfer

The whisper to ComfortPro (12 seconds, Sarah on hold)

> *"Hot lead — Sarah Martinez, Brandon (33511), single-family home 1,500-2,000 sq ft, current system 18 years old, ASAP timeline, qualified, not talking to other contractors. Connecting you now."*

The three-way intro (18 seconds)

> *"Sarah, I have Erik on the line from ComfortPro HVAC — they handle the highest-rated replacement work in the Tampa metro and I think they'll be able to help you. Erik, Sarah is the homeowner in Brandon with the 18-year-old system, ready for an estimate as soon as you can get her on the calendar."*

Marcus then goes silent. Erik takes over. Marcus drops off the line within 30 seconds.

Step 10 — Buyer accepts and books

Erik confirms Sarah's details, walks her through what to expect from the in-home estimate, books her for Thursday at 2:00 PM. ComfortPro's CRM logs the booking. The lead is officially "accepted."

11:36 AM. Total elapsed time from Sarah's first click to a booked estimate: 13 minutes.

Step 11 — Invoice and reporting

Your LeadConduit instance now generates a transaction record:

- Buyer: ComfortPro HVAC.
- Lead: Sarah Martinez (full PII).
- Status: Accepted, scheduled for estimate.
- Payable: $230.
- Recording URL + TrustedForm cert attached to the lead record.

Your invoice cycle bills ComfortPro weekly. The $230 hits your bank account on the following Tuesday.

The unit economics — Sarah, end to end

Run the math on this single lead:

Ad spend (1 click @ $7.42 CPC)	**($7.42)**
Other clicks needed for 1 form completion (avg 4 clicks @ $7.42)	**($22.26)**
Total ad cost per form submission	**($29.68)**
Form-to-qualified-lead rate (~75% on this funnel)	**—**

Total ad cost per qualified lead (avg)	**($39.57)**
Call-center cost per call (3 min × $0.45/min)	**($1.35)**
LMS + platform cost per lead (avg)	**($2.50)**
Total cost per qualified lead delivered	**($43.42)**
ComfortPro pays per accepted lead	**$230.00**
Buyer accept rate (post-transfer, avg)	**~85%**
Expected revenue per qualified lead	**$195.50**
Net contribution per qualified lead	**$152.08**

At ~$152 net per qualified lead and a steady 8-12 qualified leads per day in a single mid-tier metro, this single buyer relationship is producing $36,000-$54,000 per month in gross profit. Add Suncoast Air and BreezeFix to absorb spillover, and the metro grows to $50,000-$80,000 monthly gross profit. Replicate the geo + tier setup across 4-6 metros, and you're operating at $250,000-$500,000 monthly gross profit with a small (2-4 person) operating team.

That's what the business looks like when the playbook in your hands is executed competently. None of these numbers are guaranteed — ad costs rise, buyers churn, weather kills HVAC volume for a quarter — but the architecture is real and operators are running it today.

What can go wrong, briefly

- Buyer cap reached mid-day. Sarah's lead falls through to Tier 2 (Suncoast) at $185 instead of $230. Net contribution drops to $112 instead of $152 — still profitable, but the system is doing what it's supposed to.
- Sarah doesn't answer the callback. Speed-to-lead drops below 5 min → 30-40% contact rate after an hour. Mitigation: persistent retry sequence (5-min, 30-min, 4-hour, next-day), drip email.
- Sarah submits but qualification fails (renter, not homeowner). Disqualify cleanly. The ad spend is sunk; absorb it into your CAC.
- ComfortPro disputes the lead post-estimate ("the consumer changed their mind on the call"). Dispute resolution per the Module 4 dispute-decision-tree deliverable. Healthy operations run dispute rates of 3-7%.
- Ad CPC rises in a competitive season. Net contribution per lead drops. Monitor weekly; if net drops below your floor, pause the campaign and rebuild the creative.

The closing thought

Every component of this walkthrough — the ad copy, the landing page, the form, the script, the routing, the transfer language, the unit economics — has been covered in detail elsewhere in this playbook or in Module 5's main curriculum. What this walkthrough adds is the END-TO-END FLOW. If you can hold the whole picture in your head, you can diagnose what's broken when a metro stops performing, you can decide whether to add a buyer or pause a campaign, and you can train new agents without losing your mind.

This is the business. It's not magic. It's a sequence of well-executed steps, each of which is teachable, repeatable, and measurable.

Closing — what to do next

If you've read this playbook through, you now know more about cold-to-warm lead conversion than 90% of operators currently working in this industry. Most of them are running scripts they wrote themselves, with no objection bank, ad-hoc routing, and no formal transfer protocol.

Next steps, in order:

25. Re-read Part 1. Practice the four-element opening out loud, 20 times, until it feels natural.
26. Pick one vertical from Module 5's Intake Script Templates. Combine it with the objection responses in Part 2 of this playbook and the transfer language in Part 3. You now have a complete script for that vertical.
27. Run your first 10 calls. Record every one (with proper disclosure). Listen back. Mark every objection you handled poorly and rewrite your response.
28. Set up your routing in your LMS using one of the five models in Part 5. Start with one buyer if that's all you have; add tier waterfall as you add buyers.
29. Run the Part 6 unit economics on your actual ad spend, qualification rate, and buyer payout. If your numbers don't pencil out, fix the highest-leverage variable first (usually CPC or qualification rate).

Then keep going. The operators making real money in this business aren't smarter than you — they've just done the reps.

If you have questions specific to your vertical, your buyer relationships, or your unit economics, the mentorship tier exists for exactly that conversation. Otherwise, the playbook is yours. Use it.

— Lorenzo
Lead Broker Blueprint